9 Emotions and Politics

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9.1 Introduction

It has become the norm to start reviews of emotions in politics by observing how emotion has been ignored in political psychology, generally in favour of cognitive explanations. But such a statement is no longer accurate. Indeed, for at least the last 35 years, political psychologists have engaged seriously with emotions, developing and expanding theories and empirics, and pushing emotions ahead of cognitive-based theories as descriptors of what people do when confronted with political stimuli. The study of emotions in political psychology is now integral to the field.

Accordingly, there is also an ever-growing literature. Some works are traditional handbook chapters (Brader & Marcus, 2013; Brader et al., 2011; Marcus, 2003), while others appear as research encyclopaedia essays (e.g., Sirin & Villalobos, 2019). In addition, many edited volumes have been published (Åhäll & Gregory, 2015; Demertzis, 2017; Neuman et al., 2007; Redlawsk, 2006) and political psychology textbooks routinely include chapters on emotions (Cottam et al., 2015; Houghton, 2014).

Redlawsk and Pierce (2017) discuss three key research programmes in political psychology: affective intelligence, motivated evaluation, and ambivalence. These three generally represent the different approaches to emotions, engaging either dimensional models as in motivated evaluation (Lodge & Taber, 2013), or discrete emotions like anger, anxiety, and enthusiasm in affective intelligence theory (AIT; Marcus et al., 2000). Lavine et al.'s (2012) ambivalence theory engages both paradigms; ambivalent voters are more likely to employ in-depth, objective reasoning, while non-ambivalent voters are more likely to use motivated reasoning (see also Chapter 8).

Given the limitations of space and the existing reviews, we focus on recent research without attempting to survey the entire field. We primarily examine research on a key set of discrete emotions, putting aside both the dimensional and ambivalent perspectives. In addition to the more commonly studied emotions (anger, anxiety, and enthusiasm/hope), we highlight other discrete emotions that have important political implications. We also briefly discuss two group-oriented approaches that have gained attention more recently: moral emotions and collective emotions.

9.2 Appraisal Theory of Emotions

Appraisal theory focuses on how differences in the way people appraise their environment determine the emotions they experience. Each emotion is represented by a unique set of appraisal outcomes across various dimensions. The dimensions themselves include self-appraisal of a person's situation, such as motivational state (appetitive/aversive: see Lang et al., 1992), probability (certain/uncertain),

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and agency (self/others/circumstances; Roseman, 1984; Smith & Ellsworth, 1985). These appraisals need not be done consciously, nor need they be accurate.

Lerner and Keltner's (2000, 2001) appraisal-tendency theory refines appraisal theory by combining the dimensions that underlie discrete emotions with an evolutionary perspective on how emotions coordinate responses to situations. They write that, 'appraisal tendencies are goal-directed processes through which emotions exert effects on judgement and choice until the emotion-eliciting problem is resolved' (Lerner & Keltner, 2000, p. 477). Much of politics – especially voting – is about judgement and choice, and so understanding this role for discrete emotions is important.

Roseman (2011) generally categorises 16 of the most-studied discrete emotions into 4 families:

1. Contacting (all positive emotions): hope, joy, relief, love, pride
2. Distancing (negative emotions with **low control** potential): fear, sadness, distress, dislike, regret)
3. Attack (negative, **appetitive** emotions with **high control** potential): frustration, anger, guilt
4. Rejection (negative, **aversive** emotions with **high control** potential): disgust, contempt, shame

More specifically, the significant dimensions of emotions relevant to our discussion here are:

- Hope (uncertain, appetitive, circumstance-caused, high control potential, positive)
- Fear (uncertain, circumstance-caused, low control potential, negative)
- Anger (other-caused, appetitive, high control potential, negative)
- Contempt (other-caused, aversive, high control potential, negative)
- Disgust (circumstance-caused, aversive, high control potential, negative)
- Guilt (self-caused, appetitive, high control potential, negative)
- Shame (self-caused, aversive, high control potential, negative)

AIT addresses the first three emotions, while the next two are critically important 'rejection' emotions. The final two emotions are often classified more generally as moral and/or collective emotions (see also Chapter 19).

9.3 Discrete Emotions in Political Psychology

The study of discrete emotions in political science owes much to AIT (e.g., Marcus et al., 2000), which initially focused on different effects of enthusiasm and anxiety on political information processing and behaviour. AIT describes two affective subsystems: disposition and surveillance. The disposition system reflexively drives political behaviour based on existing beliefs and political habits, leading to enthusiasm (or its absence). The surveillance system activates under threat, causing anxiety. Anxious voters rely less on political habits, seeking out new information and behaving more akin to rational voters (see also Chapter 8).

Recent formulations of AIT add 'aversion', which, according to Brader and Marcus (2013), is defined as 'a cluster of feelings that includes anger, disgust, contempt, and hatred' (p. 179), and several studies have similarly treated *aversion* and *anger* as synonyms (e.g., Capelos, 2013). However, conflating these four emotions into one is problematic, as they are distinct emotions with distinct determinants, characteristics, and effects (e.g., Ekman & Cordaro, 2011; Fischer & Roseman, 2007; Haidt, 2003; Halperin et al., 2012; Hutcherson & Gross, 2011). In particular, anger is not aversive; as we explain below, it

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is an aggressive emotion quite different from aversive emotions like disgust or contempt (Lee & Lang, 2009; Roseman, 2011). For instance, Ryan (2012) finds that anger substantially increases information seeking, and Huddy et al. (2007) show that angry citizens are more likely to support military action.

For the remainder of this chapter, we discuss the basic traits and general effects of a set of discrete emotions, followed by highlighted topics from recent research. We focus first on the emotions of AIT: anger, anxiety, and enthusiasm. We then turn to recent work on emotions that influence politics but are not necessarily subsumed under AIT. These include contempt and disgust, along with moral emotions (Haidt, 2003; see also Chapter 19) and the emerging collective emotions perspective.

9.4 Anger

Anger is one of the most-studied emotions in political science. It is produced by appraisals of injustice (Averill, 1982), unfair outcomes (Kuppens et al., 2003), or goal blockage (Carver & Harmon-Jones, 2009). One key facet is the appraisal of another person as the cause for the anger-evoking situation, even if the person blamed had nothing to do with it (Quigley & Tedeschi, 1996). Anger is often combined with frustration, which arises from the appraisal of obstacles or circumstances being attributed as the cause (Roseman, 2011).

Behaviourally, anger is an approach emotion (e.g., Frija, 1986), as angry people are motivated to force change in another's behaviour (e.g., Sell et al., 2009), seek revenge, or otherwise hurt the target person (Fischer & Roseman, 2007). Anger arises especially when one feels control or power over the target (Fischer & Roseman, 2007; Huddy et al., 2007). For instance, people are more likely to express anger towards lower-status individuals than to higher-status people (Kuppens et al., 2004), and angry individuals prefer to allocate less to welfare recipients (Small & Lerner, 2008).

Anger is associated with reflexive decision-making. Angry people tend to rely on pre-existing heuristics (Huddy et al., 2007) thus making short-sighted inferences using stereotypes (Bodenhausen et al., 1994; Tiedens & Linton, 2001) and failing to deliberate carefully (Chaiken & Trope, 1999). Anger increases people's motivation to find information bolstering existing attitudes (MacKuen et al., 2010) and decreases their motivation to learn about candidates with whom they disagree (Redlawsk et al., 2007).

9.4.1 Recent Studies

We focus on recent studies in five areas. First, anger can contribute to political polarisation (see also Chapter 25). Anger is central to partisan identity (Huddy et al., 2015) and is induced whenever people encounter incivility directed towards their political in-group (Gervais, 2017). Gervais (2019) finds that counter-attitudinal incivility from political elites on Twitter arouses anger, decreases pride, and leads to a condemnation of the opposing party. Clifford (2019) reports that persuasive frames eliciting anger or disgust increase political issue moralisation and polarisation. Suhay and Erisen (2018) identify anger as the primary mechanism behind motivated reasoning; when people are confronted with information challenging their views, both anger and anxiety are elicited. However, only anger causes a politically biased reaction evidenced by a greater willingness to generate counterarguments. Finally, there is evidence that partisan sorting precedes issue polarisation. Mason (2015) finds sorting strengthens partisan identity, leading to increased activism, bias, and anger. Yet, despite the strong in-group/out-group effects, issue positions are not as polarised, resulting in 'a nation that

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agrees on many things but is bitterly divided nonetheless' (Mason, 2015, p. 142).

Second, anger can mobilise. Anger was central to the Tea Party movement (Sparks, 2015) and a stronger predictor than fear of voting against either Barack Obama or John McCain in 2008 (Finn & Glaser, 2010). Anger about US voter ID laws has been so mobilising that it has counterbalanced demobilisation created by the laws themselves (Valentino & Neuner, 2017). Valentino et al. (2011) also find across various forms of political participation that anger is more mobilising than enthusiasm. Lamprianou and Ellinas (2019) find anger especially motivates people who are less politically sophisticated, while shame motivates the more sophisticated. At the same time, the mobilising effects of anger may also depend on social status, particularly minority status. Phoenix (2019) documents what he calls the 'racial anger gap' in the United States. Across nearly 40 years of American elections, Black voters consistently express less anger than do Whites, especially for Democrats. Phoenix argues that by limiting anger – often for good reason – Black Americans have been less able to form political coalitions, resulting in political marginalisation. Given anger's mobilising nature, the tamping down of Black anger undermined their turnout in 2016.

Third, anger leads to increased information sharing on social media. Though there is an established link between emotional arousal and social media sharing (Berger & Milkman, 2012; see also Chapter 32), it has only recently been tested in the political domain. Tweets about the German election in 2011 evoking high-arousal emotions (anger and anxiety) were more often retweeted (Stieglitz & Dang-Xuan, 2013). Following the 2016 US presidential election, anger contributed to a rise in information sharing on Facebook and Twitter, as well as via email, over the phone, and face to face (Hoewe & Parrott, 2019).

Fourth, the effects of anger may differ by political ideology, especially regarding preferences for hierarchies and system justification. Rico et al. (2017) find that populist attitudes are driven by anger rather than fear (see also Chapter 28). Anger has also been central to opposition to healthcare reform (Banks, 2014). Vasilpoulos et al. (2018) find anger moves people with right-wing, but not left-wing, ideologies towards more authoritarian policy preferences. Anger also supports system justification, that is, the motive to 'actively defend and bolster existing social arrangements, often by denying or rationalizing injustices and other problems' (van der Toorn & Jost, 2014, p. 414; see also Chapter 37). It also encourages status-seeking behaviour, which could aid the establishment or bolstering of dominance-based hierarchies (Cabral & de Almeida, 2019). Interestingly, system justification could reduce anger in some situations. Vasilopoulos and Brouard (2019) find that higher levels of system justification caused people to experience less anger (and fear, but more hope) after the November 2015 Paris attacks.

Fifth, there appear to be links between anger and violence. Baele (2017) reports that lone-actor terrorists exhibit a combination of anger and high cognitive complexity. Matthes et al. (2019) argue that citizens' emotional reaction to terrorist threat risk depends on the number of potential offenders and the riskiness of a site (symbolic buildings and large events are high-risk, rural areas and small gatherings are low-risk). If there are many potential offenders threatening low-risk sites, anger at government increases. They also find that anger about terrorism increases support for anti-Muslim policy. Obaidi et al. (2018) examine in-group/out-group effects in a study of Muslims in Denmark. Those who identified more strongly with Muslims were 'more likely to perceive Western foreign policy as more unjust, reported greater group-based anger, and were

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more inclined to help Muslims both by non-violent and violent means' (p. 577).

9.5 Anxiety and Fear

Anxiety and fear centre on appraisals of threat. While certainly overlapping, there are some key differences. Fear dissipates more quickly than anxiety (Davis, 1998) and has an avoidance motive (Epstein, 1972). It is a response to specific, identifiable threats; anxiety is a response to diffuse threats (Macleod & Rutherford, 1992). Anxiety is primarily future-oriented, while fear focuses on the present (Sylvers et al., 2011; Tellegen, 1982). However, there has been little attention paid to these distinctions in political science, likely because it is difficult to disentangle the two emotions.

While anger is coupled with high control potential, anxiety and fear are emotions of uncertainty and low control potential. Tiedens and Linton (2001) find emotions of uncertainty result in systemic processing – thus, reducing reliance on 'expert' sources, invoking less stereotyping, and increasing attention to argument quality. They also affect perceptions of risk. For example, Lerner et al. (2003) find that fear increases estimates of risk from terrorism, while anger decreases them. Meijinders et al. (2001) find that inducing people's fear of increasing atmospheric carbon dioxide levels moves them to favour policies promoting energy conservation (see also Chapter 34).

Risk-taking seems to be influenced by anxiety and fear, with anxious people biased towards low-risk and low-reward choices (Habib et al., 2015; Raghunathan & Pham, 1999). A well-known framing effect – prospect theory (Kahneman & Tversky, 1979, 1984) – shows people are risk-averse for gains, while risk-seeking for losses. Habib et al. (2015) find that in gain frames, fear increases risk-averse choices, whereas anger *decreases* risk-averse choices. Similarly, Druckman and McDermott (2008) find that emotional effects on framing are context specific. In an investment scenario, anger and enthusiasm increase risk-taking, while distress – similar to anxiety – decreases it; in a life-or-death disease scenario, only distress affects risk-taking, again decreasing it. In the political realm, anxiety about terrorism decreases support for war and hawkish candidates, while anger increases support (Lambert et al., 2010).

The effects of anxiety on information seeking are complicated. As Maslow (1963) says, 'we can seek knowledge in order to reduce anxiety and we can also avoid knowing in order to reduce anxiety' (p. 122). There is convincing evidence for both views, since anxious people exhibit vigilance in the short term and avoidance in the long term (Mogg et al., 2004). In accordance with AIT, Valentino et al. (2008) find anxiety increases both information search and learning, and Brader (2006) shows anxious citizens are more likely to vote based upon political issues and candidate qualities, rather than partisanship. MacKuen et al. (2010) find that anxious citizens are more likely to accept compromise and more willing to engage with opposing arguments. People searching for information may also find anxiety to be helpful. For example, readers of online reviews find anxious-sounding reviews more helpful than angry-sounding reviews (Yin et al., 2014). Hunter et al. (2019) find that social anxiety is associated with increases in deliberative evaluation, even to the point of overthinking and paralysis in social situations.

While anxiety and fear can encourage deliberation, anxiety also undermines processing efficiency and performance (Eysenck & Calvo, 1992; Eysenck et al., 2007; Miu et al., 2008). Threats, whether controllable or uncontrollable, cause attentional and interpretive

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bias because people focus on too few alternatives (Keinan, 1987), though this can be countered somewhat by voluntary task-related effort (Mathews & Mackintosh, 1998). Fear can reduce a person's ability to process arguments and increase susceptibility to persuasion (Jepson & Chaiken, 1990). Nai et al. (2017) provide some nuance, as they find that political sophistication increases calm citizens' resistance to persuasion and decreases it for anxious citizens.

9.5.1 Recent Studies

We focus on recent studies in three areas, starting with the role of anxiety in information search and processing. Results for information search are mixed at best. Hoewe and Parrott (2019) find that anxiety increased information seeking and resulted in more information sharing on social media, although enthusiasm and anger had stronger effects. Redlawsk et al. (2007) find that anxiety only enhances learning about a preferred candidate in a high threat environment. Ryan (2012) finds no link between online advertisements evoking moderate levels of anxiety and increased information search measured by click-through rates. Yet, moderate levels of anger 'substantially increas[e] web users' proclivity to click through to a political website' (p. 1138). Hasell and Weeks (2016) find no link between anxiety and sharing of partisan news (though they do for anger). Cheung-Blunden and Ju (2016) showed news stories about cyberattacks to participants and found that anxiety inhibited recall, while other emotions did not. Taken together, these studies mostly question the link between anxiety and information search.

Second, fear can conditionally shift ideology and political policy preferences. In a meta-study on mortality salience and political ideology, Burke et al. (2013) find that increased mortality salience can affirm existing ideologies, but, in some cases, can elicit a shift towards conservatism, regardless of existing ideologies. For example, Weise et al. (2011) argue that increased mortality salience manifests as more negative attitudes towards immigrants for people high in right-wing authoritarianism (RWA), but more positive attitudes towards immigrants for those low in RWA. Banks and Hicks (2016) show that fearful Whites with high levels of implicit racism become more supportive of voter ID laws. Matthes et al. (2019) find that citizens become more afraid after a terrorist attack when they believe there are large number of potential offenders. They also find that fear about terrorism increases support for anti-Muslim policy.

Third, fear and anxiety reduce trust towards out-groups (Salam et al., 2017; Steen-Johnsen & Winsvold, 2019). Fear and the derogation of out-groups are particularly strong among individuals from both far left and right wings. Van Prooijen et al. (2015) find that those with extreme views expressed contempt for a larger number of social groups than did their more moderate counterparts, and right-wing extremists were particularly negative towards immigrants (see also Chapter 26). Hatemi et al. (2013) find that increases in social fear are associated with increasingly negative out-group opinions, and they manifest as negative attitudes towards immigration and positive attitudes towards segregation.

9.6 Hope and Enthusiasm

Positive emotions are understudied across disciplines. They are also more difficult to differentiate because of high correlations between them (e.g., Averill, 1980), and the fact that people experience multiple positive emotions simultaneously more often than multiple negative emotions (Barrett et al., 2001). That said, positive emotions can have distinct effects.

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Fredrickson and Cohn (2008, p. 779) explain that, while response tendencies for positive emotions are broad and flexible, 'low-arousal positive emotions are likely to have different thought–action tendencies from high-arousal ones, and ignoring these emotions impedes our ability to make specific predictions about emotions and behavior'. Cavanaugh et al. (2016) differentiated 4 positive emotions (excitement, price, contentment, and gratitude), and Tong (2015) differentiated 13.

Among the positive emotions, political psychologists have focused most on hope and enthusiasm. Both are appetitive emotions, as are positive emotions in general, and are future-orientated, although hope for the future may implicitly imply negative attitudes towards the present. Hope is coupled with appraisals of high control potential, and involves behaviours of anticipation and approach, along with the motivation to pursue goals (Roseman, 2011). It can improve problem-solving ability and be a predictor of future success (Snyder et al., 2002). In politics, hope is associated with dovish foreign policy and can motivate conflict resolution (Cohen-Chen et al., 2017). Enthusiasm is mobilising (e.g., Brader, 2006; Marcus & MacKuen, 1993), reinforces one's predilections, and is associated with reflexive, dispositional decision-making (Marcus et al., 2000). To the extent that voters feel enthusiasm for a candidate, it may mitigate effects of negative racial attitudes on candidate evaluations (Tolbert et al., 2018). Hope and enthusiasm are often used interchangeably (e.g., Boukala & Dimitrakopoulou, 2017), though Ellsworth and Smith (1988) define enthusiasm as a combination of hope and pride. In any case, hope and enthusiasm are similar enough that the political psychology literature generally does not distinguish them. In various efforts to differentiate positive emotions (Cavanaugh et al., 2016; Goetz et al., 2010; Hu et al., 2019; Shiota et al., 2014; Tong, 2015), one or the other (predominantly, hope) is usually included, but not both.

9.6.1 Recent Studies

Political psychology mostly focuses on the motivational characteristics of hope and enthusiasm. Jenkins (2018) argues that hope is the antidote for demotivation and disenchantment, and cultivating hope can generate interest, engagement, and positive affect towards politics. Though negativity remains a staple of modern politics, hope still has an effect at the polls. For example, in the 2016 Iowa caucuses, hope for one of the three major GOP candidates (Trump, Cruz, and Rubio) predicted an increased probability of voting for that candidate (Redlawsk et al., 2018). Valisopoulou and Wagner (2017) find that when pro-European Union groups create enthusiasm, citizens are mobilised in favour of European integration. Tweets increase enthusiasm for those who agree with the message, but only if they are uncivil – likely because incivility is entertaining (Kosmidis & Theocharis, 2020).

Hoewe and Parrott (2019) find enthusiasm encourages political information sharing. Collins and Block (2020) studied mobilisation of African Americans, finding a substitution effect between enthusiasm and civic duty. While both increase mobilisation, high levels of civic duty can compensate for low levels of enthusiasm, and vice versa. Stolwijk et al. (2017) show that voters are more likely to vote for a party after being exposed to positive poll coverage about that party; thus, enthusiasm is a main driver of the bandwagon effect.

At the same time, Phoenix (2019) argues that hope predicts higher turnout in the USA among Whites but not Blacks, even in 2008 and 2012 with Barack Obama on the ballot. Instead, pride correlates with turnout

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for Black voters, because it 'is rooted in a fervent belief in one's own capacity to get the job done' (p. 181), whereas hope does not augment similar perceptions of agency. This interaction is intriguing and worth additional scholarly focus.

Hope plays a significant role in the rise of populism (see also Chapter 28). Although populists certainly appeal to anger and fear (e.g., Salmela & von Scheve, 2017, 2018; Wodak, 2015), they regularly use positive emotions. In the UK's vote to leave the EU, the UK Independence Party (UKIP) used more emotionally laden content (vs Labour) and projected a higher frequency of positive emotions (Breeze, 2019). Populism encourages beleaguered citizens to buy into a positive view of the future and to believe that it is in their control, rather than in the hands of elites (Curato, 2016). In the Philippines, supporters of Rodrigo Duterte collectively felt hope and euphoria (but also contempt: Montiel & Uyheng, 2020). They felt a 'reclaimed sense of democratic agency' and were spurred towards political action (Curato, 2016, p. 102). In the USA, Donald Trump provided hope for those who were struggling economically (Hochschild, 2016); Reicher and Haslam (2016) describe a Trump rally as 'an identity festival that embodied a politics of hope' (p. 29). Depending on its use, hope can either fracture social cleavages or heal them; affective polarisation increases with in-group enthusiasm and decreases with out-group enthusiasm (McLaughlin et al., 2020).

9.7 Rejection Emotions: Contempt and Disgust

Brader and Marcus (2013) include anger, disgust, and contempt as a single undifferentiated set of 'aversive' emotions in AIT. Some evidence is developing that suggests this approach does not encompass a full range of negative responses in politics. As we noted earlier, Ekman and Cordaro (2011) argue for distinguishing between these three specific emotions, as each has distinct antecedents, effects, and expressions. Roseman (2011, 2013; Fischer & Roseman, 2007) argues that many specific emotions show variation in response profiles, as well as 'consistency across many instances of the same emotion' (2011, p. 435). His model groups emotions into four families: positive, distancing, attack, and rejection. In the context of affective intelligence, political psychologists have generally considered only two of the three negative families: distancing (fear/anxiety) and attack (anger). The third family, rejection, has been broadly absent.

We argue that politics clearly engages rejection emotions at least as readily as the others. Anyone who has spent even brief moments watching negative campaign advertising has certainly felt the contempt or disgust that is meant to be engendered towards the target of the ad (Mattes & Redlawsk, 2014). These two emotions have particular resonance in the political realm.

9.7.1 Contempt

Anger and contempt occupy similar spaces in Roseman's (2011) typology, yet they have important differences and can be readily disentangled. Anger has at its root the perception that others are taking unjust actions, while contempt is elicited by perceptions that others are inferior (Fischer & Roseman, 2007; Hutcherson & Gross, 2011). Thus, contempt is a trait-focused emotion centred on people and their incompetence, stupidity, or corruption, while anger is outcome-focused (Roseman, 2018).

Voters get angry at politicians who are perceived to treat them unfairly, but they feel contempt towards those who appear to be incompetent or corrupt. A political candidate who uses contempt to push voters away from

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the opponent can enhance these perceptions. Voters may perceive that bad outcomes can be changed, while bad people cannot. Politically, then, getting voters to feel contempt for one's opponent is different from getting them to feel angry about what the opponent does. Mattes et al. (2018) show evidence of contempt in negative advertising, with voters recognising its presence and reacting with felt contempt towards candidates, even from their own party.

Roseman et al. (2020; also Johnston et al., 2014) show that when both anger and contempt are included in a model of emotional responses to candidates, contempt can be a more powerful predictor of voting behaviour than anger. There are limits, though, and the use of contempt by politicians can backfire. When efforts to create contempt for an opponent move into personally defamatory or uncivil language that violates norms of respectful discourse, contempt may rebound on the attacker (Frimer & Skitka, 2018; Mattes & Redlawsk, 2014).

Contempt would seem to be a fruitful area of research in politics, especially in the context of elections. One way to win is to attempt to push one's opponent beyond some line of acceptability, to convince voters that they are not even worthy of consideration. Donald Trump has routinely attempted to do this – for example, by using belittling nicknames for his political opponents. Many other politicians clearly foment contempt, and its use may be on the rise (Stohr, 2017). Grimmer and King (2011) document that more than a quarter of US senators' press releases from 2005 to 2007 used 'exaggerated language to put them down or devalue their ideas' (p. 2649). A better understanding of when and how contempt works in politics would be valuable.

9.7.2 Disgust

As another rejection emotion, disgust is related to, but distinguishable from, contempt (Miceli & Castelfranchi, 2018), and shame (see Section 9.8.1), where the self or group is seen as substandard (Roseman, 2013). Disgust is a response to potential contamination and acts to distance people from sources of infection, motivating physical distancing and the avoidance of that which is disgusting. Where the objects of contempt are typically other people, objects of disgust can be human or non-human.

Significantly more research has been done on the role of disgust (vs contempt) in politics. One focus has been 'disgust sensitivity', a personality trait indicating the extent to which a person is likely to feel disgust. Typical is Shook et al. (2017), who find that those with greater sensitivity towards disgust were less likely to vote for Obama in 2012, with disgust sensitivity associated with a higher likelihood of identifying as Republican and supporting conservative values. Other studies have found stronger reactions to disgusting stimuli among conservatives compared to liberals (Ahn et al., 2014).

Yet there seems to be little research on how voters are influenced by the feeling of disgust generated by political candidates during a campaign. More typical are studies on policy issues which may evoke a disgust reaction due to perceived moral purity violations, such as same-sex marriage and abortion (Adams et al., 2014; Inbar et al., 2009), and some health-related issues (Clifford & Wendell, 2016).

Disgust may also affect willingness to learn new information in certain threatening contexts such as infectious disease. Clifford and Jerit (2018) manipulated information about a disease outbreak and report that when disgust is high in the context of such a threat, learning is attenuated, as people avoid information about the disease. Yet, Park (2015) finds that, among Twitter users in South Korea, increased feelings of disgust (along with anger) motivate more information seeking, not less.

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The difference may be in the nature of the information. Park examines 'negative news stories', which may not raise the direct personal threat to purity that fears of an infectious disease create.

9.8 Two Group-Oriented Perspectives on Emotions

In addition to the specific emotions approach, political researchers have begun to put more focus on social contexts. Emotions are more than simply the reactions of atomised individuals to stimuli. We read each other's emotions as part of social interaction, and humans regularly respond to what we perceive from others through a process of emotional contagion (Elfenbein, 2014; Hatfield et al., 1994). As such, two more socially focused approaches may have much to say about the political world generally. Moral emotions have both individual and group effects, as people can personally experience emotions that connect to their own sense of moral behaviour, as well as experience emotions on behalf of, and about, in- and out-groups. Collective emotions go beyond the self and may help bind people to social groups and even nation-states.

9.8.1 Moral Emotions

In general, moral emotions connect behaviour and moral standards (Giner-Sorolla, 2012; Halperan & Schori-Eyal, 2019). Haidt (2003, p. 853) defines them functionally as 'linked to the interests or welfare either of society as a whole or at least of persons other than the judge or agent'. Thus, moral emotions are not simply about individual responses to stimuli, but also their embeddedness in affinity or antipathy towards groups. A given emotion may or may not act as a moral emotion, depending on whether it (1) is triggered by situations that do not directly harm or benefit the self and/or (2) involves prosocial action tendencies (Haidt, 2003). Anger can be moral in some contexts (Hutcherson & Gross, 2011), for example, when generated by the behaviour of a government towards some of its citizens, as long as the person feeling the anger is not personally targeted. Disgust may be considered a moral emotion (Bloom, 2014) when it is socially orientated, such as in response to certain types of 'deviant' behaviour (as opposed to disgust felt in seeing a dead animal on the road).

Halperin and Schori-Eyal (2019) write that, 'moral emotions influence the link between moral standards and moral behaviour, driving people to behave in moral, socially appropriate ways in their social interactions and intimate relationships'. In intergroup emotions theory (Smith & Mackie, 2016), moral emotions work at both individual and group levels, so when one holds a group identity, emotions generated by behaviours of group members can be positive, such as taking pride in group action. They can also be negative, as when the group's behaviour generates guilt or shame. In both cases, emotions are responses to actions of group members and, while felt by the individual, are about one's relationship to the group (Lickel et al., 2011).

Haidt (2003) distinguishes four families of moral emotions: other-condemning; self-conscious; other-suffering; and other-praising. Anger, contempt, and disgust are the typical other-condemning emotions. When considered as a moral, rather than non-moral, emotion, anger is related to demands for restoration of moral order and can be generated by the perceived unfair treatment of a group. Disgust has a prosocial action tendency, with punishment for culturally inappropriate behaviour. Contempt weakens the experience of other moral emotions towards its object.

Self-conscious emotions are felt about oneself in relation to others. These generally

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include shame, guilt, pride and embarrassment (Tangney et al., 2007). Shame is felt individually when a moral violation is committed and others know about it. As a group emotion, shame can be experienced when fellow in-group members act in immoral or inappropriate ways. Guilt may be the response when one feels personally complicit in the action taken by the group. Pride rewards morally correct choices and behaviour and motivates conformity to moral standards (Tangney et al., 2007).

Sympathy and compassion are in the other-suffering family. Eisenberg (1986) argues that sympathy is elicited by perceiving suffering and need not require experiencing the other person's feeling. Sympathy and compassion can generate helping behaviour and altruism (Tangney et al., 2007). The fourth category, the other-praising emotions, include elevation and gratitude (Haidt, 2003) and occur when experiencing positive moral behaviour by others, like kindness and loyalty.

Lickel et al. (2011) and Halperin and Schori-Eyal (2019) summarise the research on the self-conscious emotions of shame and guilt. In particular, the latter suggest that guilt can reduce violent intergroup relations. The strength of group affiliation combined with an appraisal implicating one's own responsibility by association can lead to experiencing guilt and other self-conscious emotions. In a political context, these moral emotions may be influenced by the violation of moral values by group members or leaders (Walter & Redlawsk, 2021). Recent work by Salmela and von Scheve (2018) argues that both left- and right-wing populism are characterised by shame, with the former a factor of 'repressed shame' and the latter 'acknowledged shame'.

9.8.2 Collective Emotions

Collective emotions provide another way to think about emotions in groups, including both social groups and states within the international order. While for the most part the moral emotions approach focuses on individual feelings in response to morally focused actions of groups, collective emotions emphasise sharing emotions within a group in response to events and actions implicating it. Mercer (2014) locates these group-level emotions in social identification, arguing that, while the feelings can be the same, collective emotion can be distinguished from individual emotion because the locus of the feeling is not about oneself, but about what is observed about a group.

The challenge, as laid out by Hutchison and Bleiker (2014, p. 492), is to 'theorize the processes through which individual emotions become collective and political'. Collective emotions have been advanced by scholars of social movements (Goodwin et al., 2001; see Chapter 31) and in international relations more generally, but not without controversy. Rational actor models have dominated these fields, even when it would seem to be difficult to ascribe the behaviour of a group or state to a rational calculus. Some of the complexities in applying emotions to social groups and the actions of states are laid out by Mattern (2014), who writes that, while she is convinced about emotions' role in world politics, she is also 'increasingly skeptical of my own conviction' (p. 589). Nonetheless, as Bar-Tal et al. (2007) argue, group emotions can be meaningfully different from individual emotions in that they are caused by group-related experiences and operate in a social environment.

Collective emotions support the emergence, maintenance, and development of social groups. Identity groups can arise when the emotions of individuals converge on an important shared topic. For instance, shared anger at oppression or shared guilt about collective wrongdoing to a third party plays an important role in the emergence of social and

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political movements (Salmela, 2014). Collective emotions maintain groups by giving group members feelings of closeness and solidarity. And collective guilt and remorse and expecting group apologies for certain behaviours hold groups accountable for their actions (Huebner, 2011).

Gould (2004) argues that social movements require emotional responses; these are what 'political organizers appeal to, arouse, manipulate, and sustain to recruit and retain members' (p. 158). However, the place of collective emotions in political mobilisation remains underexplored though potentially fruitful. For example, Montiel and Uyheng (2020) provide insight into populism in the global south by focusing on collective emotions of its supporters. Basta (2020) develops the concept of collective exhaustion master frames that narrate the aggrieved community's arrival to a threshold of collective impatience, arguing such narratives legitimise radical departures from prevailing political habits (a cognitive task) and stimulate collective impatience with the political status quo (an emotional management task). Another promising approach by Sirin et al. (2016) is Group Empathy Theory. They argue that standard theories of collective emotions assume emotions engage the same psychological processes in all individuals. What is missing is a theory for sub-groups within a broader society, particularly the responses of minority groups versus majority groups. Broadly speaking, discrete emotional responses to an incident hurting members of a group may be mixed with responses unique to subgroups. Minority group members, for example, may have experiences that create empathy between them and the target of a hate crime, which majority group members might not feel, even as both groups are sympathetic (see also Sirin & Villalobos, 2019). This is similar to Phoenix's (2019) argument about Black anger in the USA.

The current trend in political psychology shows a broadening of scope in the study of emotions. While the primary focus remains on AIT with its emphasis on anger, fear, and enthusiasm, a distinct role exists for an array of other important, but less studied, emotions. In this, we agree with Sirin and Villalobos', 2019) call for expanding the range of emotions studied by political psychologists. Doing so will no doubt broaden our understanding of how people relate to the political world.

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